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The 5 Marketing Frameworks for Trades Businesses

The five systems that decide whether marketing money turns into booked work — and why most businesses have four running badly and one missing entirely.

FOR OWNERS DOING $1M+ · BUILT BY ASP

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What is in here

Five systems, in order. Each one feeds the next.

BEFORE YOU START

This is written for one person: the owner of a home-service business doing a million or more a year, who can tell you exactly what the crew costs and exactly what the trucks cost, but cannot tell you which channel produced last month's jobs. If someone asks, the honest answer is "probably Google."

That gap comes from how the business is wired, not from a lack of discipline.

What follows is the five systems that decide whether marketing money turns into booked work, and the reasons most trades businesses have four of them running badly and one missing entirely. Trace the lead back to where it came from. Respond fast enough to win it. Run the listing that produces the most of them. Know what you can afford to spend to get one. Convert it on a site built to book work.

Each one feeds the next. Fixing the fifth while the first is broken is how businesses spend three years busy and no richer.

Each one turns the next. Let one seize up and the rest slow down.

One boundary worth naming up front: this covers measuring and converting the demand you already have. It will not tell you where to spend your next dollar — that is channel strategy, and it is not what this covers. Fix the measuring first and that question answers itself.

FRAMEWORK 1

THE LEAD SOURCE MAP

Knowing which channel produced the work

What breaks

You spend money on marketing every month. At the end of it you have one number: total leads. What you do not have is which channel produced each one.

Ask most owners where the last ten jobs came from and you get guesses. It is common to find a business that has run paid ads for a year without knowing whether the ads paid for themselves. Not because nobody cared. Because nothing in the business was built to answer the question.

So every month you raise spend on the channel that feels busy and cut the one that quietly booked four jobs. Nobody can prove either call was right, so next month you guess again. That is the real cost: not one bad month, but a decade of decisions nobody could prove were right.

Why it breaks

Every lead crosses two systems before it becomes a job. There is the place it was born — an ad, a search result, your Business Profile. And there is the place it lands — a form, a phone call, a text.

Those two systems do not talk to each other by default. A phone call carries no label saying the caller clicked an ad. A Business Profile click does not announce itself; it arrives looking exactly like someone who typed your name from memory.

Tracing a lead means labeling it at birth, carrying that label to wherever it lands, and storing it somewhere permanent. Break any one of the three and the trail goes cold. Most businesses break all three, which is why the answer feels unknowable rather than merely missing.

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What has to be true

1. **Every entry point is labeled.** Every link you control — website, booking, listing, posts, email — carries a tag identifying where the click came from. Untagged traffic collapses into "direct," and direct is indistinguishable from someone who already knew your name. This is the cheapest fix in this guide and the one most often skipped.
2. **A conversion is not a customer.** A conversion records one action: somebody tapped to call, or submitted a form. That is all it means. It does not mean the job was booked, and it does not mean the caller was a customer you want. A campaign can produce a pile of conversions and still lose money, because volume says nothing about quality. Good data in, good data out — getting the right leads into the system is the first step to a marketing system worth trusting.
3. **The CRM — whatever system holds your customer and job records — is the system of record, not the ad platform.** Source lives on the customer record, written automatically, never typed in later from memory. If the source field is not on the record, no amount of tagging upstream will save you.
4. **Access is settled before you need it.** Analytics permissions, historical exports, and the linkage between advertising and search data are things you discover are wrong at the exact moment you need a year of history you no longer have. Search history in particular expires on a rolling window. Nobody notices until they want it.
5. **Every channel is accounted for, including the ones that bypass your website.** Some advertising products deliver leads to their own inbox and never touch your site or your CRM. A business can run one of these for a year and have no record it produced anything.

6 **The phone is treated as a real channel or honestly excluded.** A large share of trades work arrives by phone, and a call from a listing leaves no trace in web analytics because no page ever loads. You can close that gap with a paid tracking layer, or you can accept the blind spot. What you cannot do is pretend the number in your dashboard is complete when it excludes the way most of your customers contact you.

7 **What cannot be traced is named out loud.** Word of mouth, walk-ins, the person who heard your name at a job site and searched for you three weeks later — none of it leaves a digital trail. No system captures it. Any vendor who says otherwise is selling you a number they invented.

HOW YOU KNOW IT IS WORKING

Pull thirty recent leads. Every one has a source on the record — not guessed, not blank, not "website" for all thirty. Pick five and trace them backwards to the click or call that created them. If all five reconcile, the wiring holds.

THE TRAP

Believing the ad platform over your own records. Every platform reports more conversions than your CRM will, because it counts things your business does not: repeat clicks, view-throughs, people who never contacted you. When the two disagree — and they will — the CRM is the one counting work you can invoice.

• FRAMEWORK 2

SPEED TO LEAD

Winning the job before the competition answers

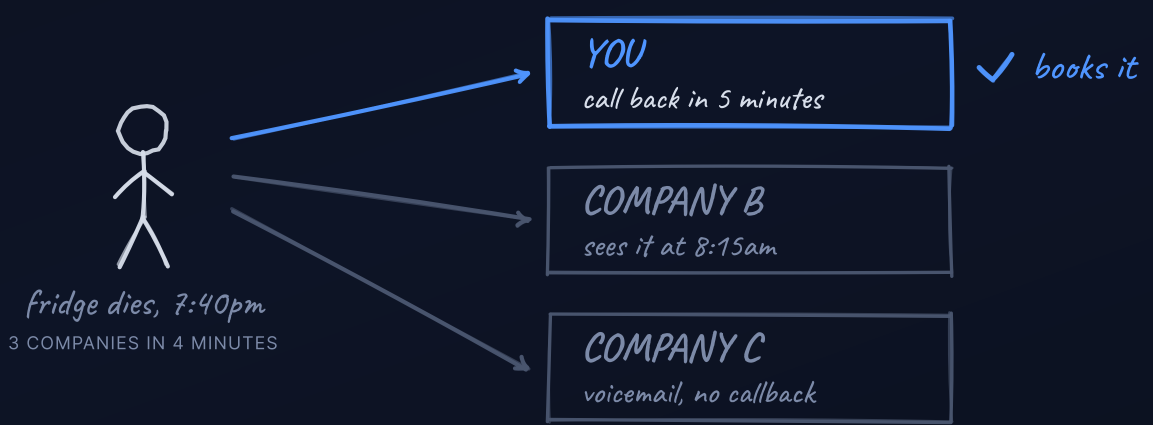
What breaks

A homeowner's refrigerator dies at 7:40 on a Tuesday. They contact three companies in four minutes. One from a listing, one from a form, one by phone.

Whoever calls back first probably books the job. The best technician and the nicest truck do not matter if they call back second.

Most businesses lose that race without knowing a race happened. The form lands in an inbox nobody watches after five. The missed call sits in a log until morning. By 8:15 the homeowner has someone else's tech on the way. It gets recorded as "went with someone else." That is not what happened. You were slow.

The part that stings: you paid for that lead. Ad spend, ranking, reviews, referral goodwill — all of it worked. The homeowner chose you. Then the handoff broke inside your own business.



The buyer is not comparing quality. They are comparing who picked up.

Why it breaks

The problem is rarely that nobody wants the lead. Plenty of businesses are short on work and want it badly. The problem is that nobody is positioned to catch it the moment it lands. The owner is on a job. The office manager is on the phone with a supplier, then a customer disputing an invoice, then a tech who needs a part. The lead does not arrive as an interruption anyone is free to take. It arrives as one more item in a stack.

Then there is the channel problem. Calls ring somewhere. Forms go to email. Listing messages sit inside an app. Texts go to whatever number is on the truck. Four destinations, and no single person watching all four.

Nights and weekends are worse, where coverage is usually "the owner checks their phone sometimes." Emergency work — the highest-margin work most businesses do — arrives precisely then.

Nobody is being careless. There is no named owner, no clock, and no rule. So leads sit.

What has to be true

1. **Every channel has a named owner, by shift.** Not "whoever sees it." One name, on a calendar, so everyone knows who is up. Shared responsibility is the same as none.
2. **There is a stated clock, and everyone knows it.** A response standard nobody says out loud is not a standard. It also has to differ by hour — what is acceptable at 8pm is not acceptable at 2pm, when someone is sitting at the desk. Hold the daytime standard tight and set an honest one for after hours.
3. **No lead's only destination is an email inbox.** Email is where leads go to die. Every channel needs a destination that makes noise on a person's phone.
4. **Failure escalates automatically.** If the owner does not touch a lead inside the window, it moves to someone else, and eventually to you. Without escalation, the clock is decoration.
5. **Automation buys a few minutes. A person still has to book the job.** An instant reply holds a homeowner's attention for a while. A human still has to call. Businesses that automate the acknowledgment and skip the call have automated losing more politely.
6. **One attempt is not follow-up.** Most businesses call once and stop. The lead who does not answer the first call is not gone; they are in a shower, on a ladder, or driving. A real cadence spans days and channels.
7. **After hours is covered on purpose or conceded on purpose.** Live answer, or an answering service that reaches a human immediately. Voicemail alone is a decision to lose the emergency work — which is a legitimate choice, as long as it is a choice.

HOW YOU KNOW IT IS WORKING

Measure time-to-first-touch: minutes between arrival and a human attempting contact. An auto-reply does not count.

Look at it three ways. By channel — one will be far worse than the others, and that is your first fix. By hour — nights and weekends separately, because that is where the disaster hides. And by median *and* worst case, because the average is a liar. Nine leads called in four minutes and one called eleven hours later averages out fine and still lost a job.

Then test yourself. Have someone fill out your form on a Saturday morning and call your main line at 8pm. Time both. Do it monthly. It will tell you more than any report.

THE TRAP

Fixing the tool and skipping the rule. Businesses add a notification, a phone system, a text alert. Now four devices ping and nobody acts, because everyone assumes someone else will.

Speed to lead comes down to ownership — who is responsible, on the clock, right now. One name responsible, one clock everyone can see, one consequence if it is missed. Tools only help after that exists.

• FRAMEWORK 3

3

THE PROFILE AS A CHANNEL

Turning a listing into something you can measure

What breaks

Most trades businesses have a Google Business Profile. Almost none run it. It sits there with a phone number, some old photos, and a review score nobody manages on purpose. The owner looks at it twice a year, usually after a bad review.

A Profile nobody runs still shows up in search. It still produces calls and quote requests. You are simply not getting credit for them, and not improving your odds of appearing next time.

Here is what it costs. When a homeowner searches for your trade near them, the map result is a short list — usually three. If your Profile is thin and a competitor's is complete, you lose the spot before your name is ever seen. Not because of price or workmanship. Because of a listing you never finished.

Why it breaks

The ranking works on relevance, distance, and prominence. Relevance is built from fields owners skip. Distance is fixed once service areas are set honestly. Prominence is reviews and activity, and it rewards volume, recency, and consistency rather than one good push.

Most owners treat the Profile as a business card. The platform treats it as a live feed it has to keep re-scoring. A Profile with no new photo, post, or review in three months reads as stale, however healthy the business behind it.

What has to be true

1. **The primary category is right.** It is the single highest-impact field, and it is where most trades businesses quietly lose. Too broad and you compete with everyone; too narrow and you disappear from the search that matters. Everything else is optimization on top of this one decision.
2. **The service area reflects where a truck really goes.** Claiming a whole state to seem bigger dilutes relevance everywhere, including in the town you own outright.

3. **Reviews are a system, not a hope.** The ask happens at job completion, in person, before the crew leaves — the highest-converting moment you will ever have. It is trained, scripted the same way every time, and it never involves an incentive or a filter that asks only the happy ones. Both break platform rules and both risk the listing. Volume, recency and pace all matter: forty reviews from three years ago loses to twenty-five that keep arriving.
4. **Every review gets a reply.** A short, specific, non-defensive answer to a bad review does more for the next reader than the review itself.
5. **Activity is continuous, not seasonal.** Real job photos, not stock. Posts on a cadence, understanding they expire. A gallery from your launch is worse than nothing because it dates you.
6. **Every link on the Profile is tagged.** This is the step almost nobody takes and the reason owners believe their Profile "does not produce anything." Untagged, every click lands in analytics as direct traffic and the Profile looks invisible while it drives real work. Tagging is minutes of effort and it converts the listing from a rumor into a measurable channel.
7. **The questions section is owned.** It is public and anyone can answer. Seed the five questions you get by phone every week, or let a stranger's guess stand as your answer.
8. **One limit is acknowledged.** A call placed straight from the listing leaves no trace in web analytics, because no page ever loads. The dashboard shows the call happened. Nothing shows what it became unless you close that gap deliberately.

HOW YOU KNOW IT IS WORKING

Every field complete. Photos inside thirty days. Reviews arriving weekly or every other week rather than in bursts, each with a reply. A post inside the last week.

Then the real test: open your analytics and find Profile traffic identified by source. If you cannot, the tagging is not done, however good the listing looks.

THE TRAP

Treating the Profile as a setup rather than a system. Fill it out once, push for reviews at launch, walk away for a year. The ranking rewards ongoing activity. A Profile that was complete eighteen months ago is competing against one that was updated this week.

FRAMEWORK 4

THE MONEY MATH

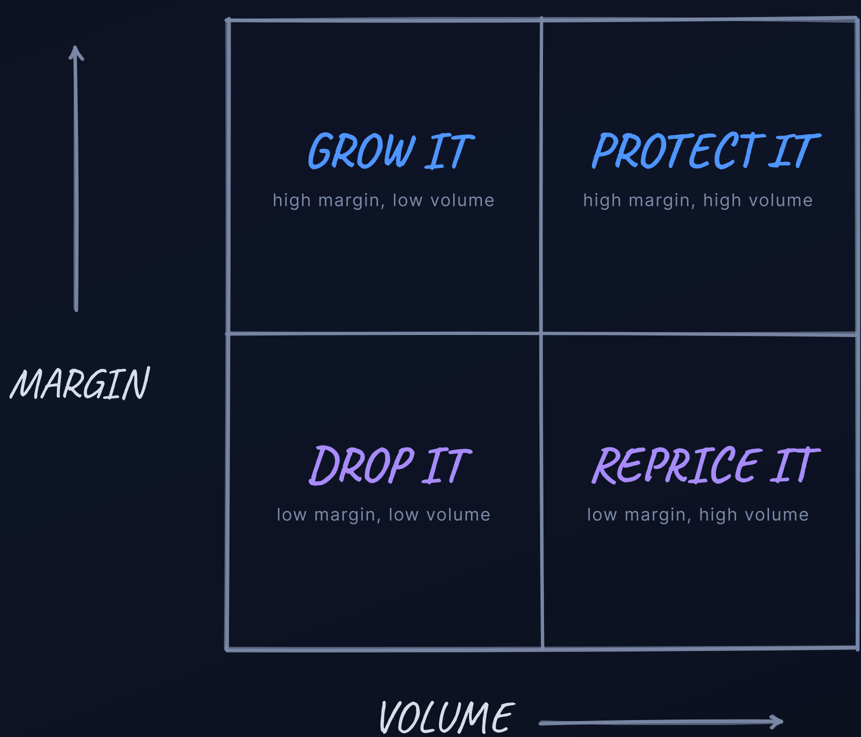
Knowing what you can afford to spend to win a job

What breaks

Most owners can state revenue for the year. Fewer can say which job type made money and which lost it. Fewer still can say what a job has to cost before it stops being worth taking.

A business running installs, service calls and maintenance under one blended margin is flying with half the instruments dark. The blended number might read 32% and look healthy. Underneath, service could be running at 60% and installs at 20% — the service side quietly funding every truck, every ad dollar and every payroll run while the install side bleeds.

You cannot fix a job type you cannot see. And you cannot judge a marketing channel without knowing what winning a job is worth.



A blended margin puts every job type in the same box.

Why it breaks

Most trades books cannot answer this, and it is not the owner's fault. It is how the accounts are built.

Field labor often sits in overhead instead of being counted as a direct cost of the job it went to, so it never attaches to the work that consumed it. The hourly rate paid to a tech is rarely loaded with what the hour truly costs — payroll taxes, workers comp, benefits, and the paid hours that are never billable. Owner pay taken as a draw (cash pulled from the business, not run through payroll) rather than salary makes the business look leaner than it is. Without job-type tracking, everything averages into one number that hides the loser.

You will not see a red flag for this. You will just notice you are busy and the account never grows.

What has to be true

1. **Labor is cost-loaded, not paid at the flat wage.** The number on the paycheck is not what the hour costs. Add employment costs and divide by the hours that can genuinely be billed, not the hours paid. The gap between those two figures is where "profitable" jobs go to die.
2. **Overhead is recovered per billable hour — call that number your recovery rate.** Every hour a tech can sell has to carry its share of rent, admin, trucks, insurance and marketing. Below that rate, you are paying to do the job rather than getting paid for it.
3. **Margin is known by job type, never blended.** This is the whole framework in one line. A blended margin cannot tell you which work to chase and which to reprice.
4. **There is a ceiling on what a job is worth winning.** Job value multiplied by its margin gives you the money the job truly produces. Deciding what share of that you will spend to acquire it converts marketing from a feeling into arithmetic. Different job types support wildly different ceilings — the same channel at the same price can be reckless for a service call and cheap for an install.
5. **Channels are judged against that ceiling, not against each other.** Cost per lead divided by close rate (the share of leads that turn into paid jobs) gives cost per booked job. Compare that to the ceiling for that job type. A channel is not expensive or cheap in isolation; it is expensive or cheap against specific work.
6. **Cheap conversions are not the same as cheap work.** A channel can deliver conversions at a third the price of another and still be the worse buy, because the people it sends never book. Judge on cost per booked job, never on conversion count. This is the same point as Framework 1 from the money side: volume of leads is not the measure, quality is.

7. **Two numbers drive everything, and both live in the CRM.** Average job value and close rate. If they are not tracked, every pricing and marketing decision downstream is a guess wearing a spreadsheet.

8. **Seasonality is respected.** A channel that looks costly in the slow month may be the thing keeping the crew paid. A cheap lead in your busiest month, on work you would have booked anyway, is not cheap.

HOW YOU KNOW IT IS WORKING

You can answer four questions without opening a spreadsheet someone else built. What does an hour of crew time truly cost. What is the rate below which you lose money. Which job type is your best margin and which is your worst. And what is the most you can spend to win each one.

If any answer needs a guess, the books are not ready to make decisions from yet. That is a conversation with your bookkeeper, not a marketing problem.

THE TRAP

Pricing off a blended margin. It feels like knowing your numbers, because there is a number. But it cannot tell you which work to grow and which to fix. Run it by job type, or next year can look bigger on paper and still make less money.

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• FRAMEWORK 5

THE SITE THAT BOOKS WORK

Structure that converts a homeowner in a hurry

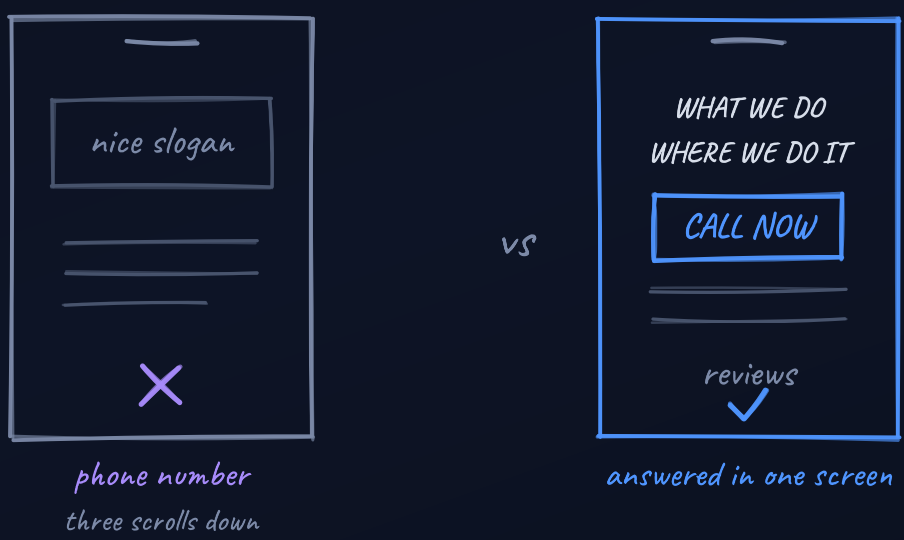
What breaks

A homeowner just found a problem. A crack across the patio slab. A refrigerator that stopped overnight. An inspection report that flagged something serious before closing.

The customer is not browsing. They are on a phone, near the broken thing, with three tabs open to three companies that look identical.

Most trades sites lose the customer in ten seconds. The homepage opens with a slogan instead of answering their only three questions: what do you do, do you cover me, how fast can I reach you. They scroll hunting for a phone number that is not there, and land on someone else's tab.

This is a structure problem. A site can look excellent and still fail to book work, because looking excellent and converting a stressed homeowner holding a phone in one hand are different jobs.



Why it breaks

Most trades sites are built by whoever built the last one — a template vendor, a relative, a marketer copying a competitor. Templates are written for browsing, not for urgency. They lead with brand before need and location. They bury the phone number in a menu. They ask for ten form fields because more fields feel more professional.

None of that matches how a homeowner behaves when a floor is buckling underfoot.

What has to be true

1. **The first screen answers what, where, and how to start.** Before any scrolling, on a phone. A slogan in that space is a wasted screen.
2. **Every service you sell has its own page.** One page listing three services competes for none of them. Each page answers the single question a homeowner types when they are ready to hire.
3. **City pages exist only where a truck goes, and say something true about that place.** A thin page repeating the homepage with a swapped name is worse than no page at all.
4. **Proof sits next to the decision.** Reviews near the top, close to the phone number. Real job photos on the page for that exact work. Licensing and insurance visible without hunting. People decide fast, and proof two scrolls away arrives after the decision.
5. **The form asks only what is needed to call someone back.** Every field past that costs leads. Someone standing over a dead appliance is not working through a dropdown.
6. **The phone number is visible and tappable on every screen.** On mobile it will out-perform any form. Never make someone hunt for it to avoid filling something in.
7. **The site is fast.** A homeowner comparing three companies will not wait. Every second before the page is usable is a reason to try the next tab.
8. **Every page reports what it produced.** Form completions, phone taps, and which page they happened on. A page you cannot measure is a page you are guessing about — and it connects straight back to Framework 1, because a site that cannot name its own conversions cannot feed the CRM a source.

HOW YOU KNOW IT IS WORKING

Open your own site on your phone. In one screen, without scrolling, can a stranger tell what you do, where you work and how to reach you? Can they tap to call without hunting?

Then check the structure. One page per real service. City pages that would not survive a find-and-replace of the town name. And finally the numbers: if the site cannot tell you which page produced a call or a form, that is the next fix, before another word of copy changes.

THE TRAP

Treating the homepage as the whole strategy. Owners spend months perfecting one page and leave every service and city page thin or missing. A homeowner searching for a specific job rarely lands on your homepage — they land on the page answering their exact question, if it exists. A superb homepage with five weak service pages loses to a plain one with ten strong pages, every time.

THE PRACTICAL PART: SOURCE TRACKING IN YOUR CRM

What to set up, depending on what you already run

Framework 1 said the CRM has to be the system of record. This is what that means in practice, for the systems most trades businesses are already on.

You are building three things. A **field** on the customer record to hold the source. A **filler** that writes to it without anyone typing. And a **habit** for the leads that arrive by phone, because no software catches those on its own.

The field is the easy part and every system below can do it. The filler is where businesses get stuck. The habit is where they quit.

First, the part that is the same everywhere

Create one custom field on the lead or customer record. Call it Lead Source. Make it a dropdown, not free text — free text becomes forty spellings of "Google" inside a year.

Keep the list short enough that a tired office manager picks the right one at 4:55pm. Six options beats sixteen: Google Search, Google Business Profile, Paid Ads, Social, Referral, Repeat Customer.

Then make your website form pass the source into that field automatically. Every form should carry hidden fields that capture where the visitor came from before they ever typed anything. Your web person will know these as UTM values — the same tagging idea from Framework 1, just the technical name for it. The visitor never sees them. They ride along with the submission.

Housecall Pro

Custom fields live on the customer record and you can set them up yourself. The web-form connection is the piece to get right — if your site form does not push into Housecall Pro directly, leads arrive by email and someone retypes them, which is where the source gets lost.

One thing to check before you plan anything ambitious: automated connections into Housecall Pro depend on your plan tier. The higher tiers open up the direct connection. On lower tiers you may be limited to what the built-in integrations offer. Confirm which tier you are on before you promise yourself an automated setup.

Jobber

Custom fields are straightforward and available on client records. Jobber's own request form can carry hidden values, so a lead that comes through it can arrive already labeled.

The gap is usually work booked over the phone, which lands in Jobber with no source at all unless whoever answers picks one. That is the habit half of the job.

ServiceTitan

ServiceTitan already thinks in campaigns, and that is both the strength and the trap. It ties a lead to a campaign through the phone number that was called. That works well for phone leads and not at all for form fills unless you wire the form to pass a campaign in.

If you are on ServiceTitan, your setup work is less about creating fields and more about making sure your web forms map into the campaign structure that already exists, rather than running a second, parallel system beside it.

HubSpot

HubSpot will do this comfortably. Create your own Lead Source property rather than relying on the source-tracking properties it fills in by itself.

Its built-in source tracking answers a different question than yours does, using its own rules about what counts. If you report off both, the two numbers will disagree and you will spend a meeting arguing about which is right. Pick your own field, populate it from your form, and treat HubSpot's native version as background.

GoHighLevel

Custom fields and hidden form fields both work well, and if your forms are built inside the platform the values carry through with no extra work.

The thing to know: if an agency set your account up, permissions and connections often sit at their level rather than yours. Ask specifically whether your location owns its own connections. If the answer is no, you do not fully control your own data, which is worth knowing before you need it.

If you are on something else, or nothing

A spreadsheet with a date, a name, a source and an outcome will answer more questions than most businesses can answer today. It does not scale, and it will not survive a busy August. But it is a real starting point, and it beats waiting until you have picked the perfect system.

THE TEST THAT WORKS ON ANY OF THEM

Book a lead through your own website form using your own phone number. Then open the record in your CRM.

If the source is sitting there without anyone typing it, the wiring works. If the field is blank, the filler is missing and everything downstream is guesswork.

Do the same thing again with a phone call, and you will find out very quickly whether the habit exists.

WHERE THIS LEAVES YOU

Five systems, in order, each feeding the next.

Most trades businesses reading this will recognize three or four of these as broken and one as entirely absent. That is normal. It is the predictable result of building a business on doing the work, not on measuring it.

If you want to start somewhere, start with the tagging in Framework 1 and the ownership rule in Framework 2. Neither costs money. Both change what you can see by the end of a month, and everything else in this guide is easier once you can see.

> ASP builds and installs these systems for trades businesses, then teaches the owner to run them. If you want a second set of eyes on yours, that is what we do.